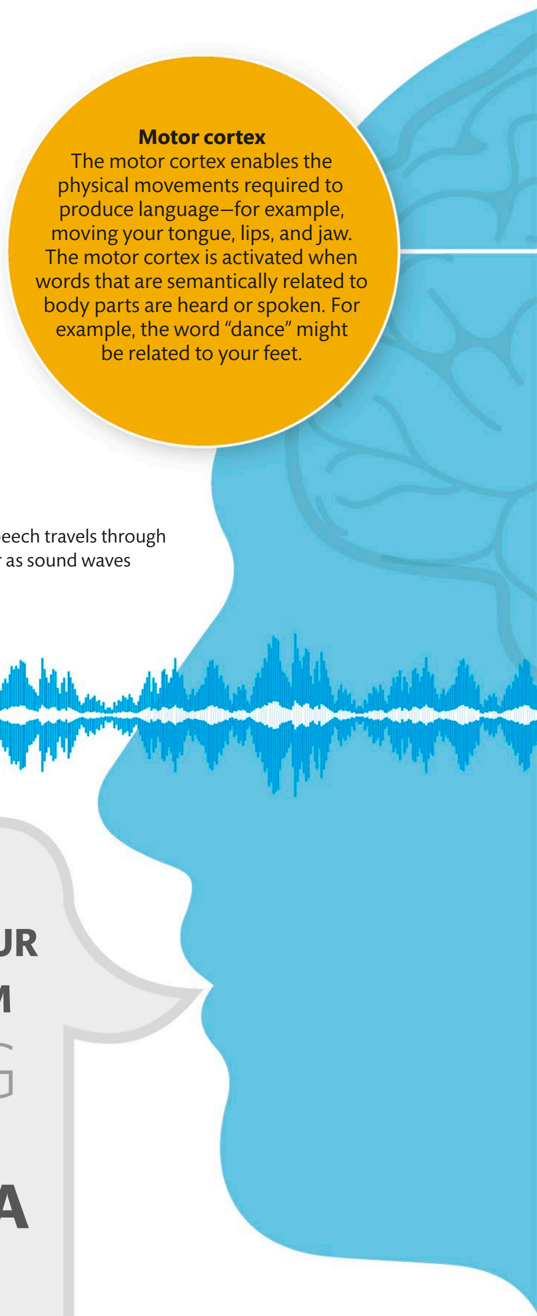
The Language Areas

The human brain, unlike that of any other animal, has areas dedicated specifically to language, usually located in its left hemisphere. The unique ability of humans to communicate using language is thought to be an evolutionary advantage.



Broca’s and Wernicke’s areas

The two main language areas are Broca’s and Wernicke’s areas. Broca’s area is associated with moving the mouth to articulate words. When learning new languages, separate parts of Broca’s area are activated when we speak either our native or non-native tongue. In Wernicke’s area, words that we hear or read are understood and selected for articulation as speech. Damage to this part of the brain can lead people to speak in peculiar ways, creating sentences that do not make sense.

BRAIN DAMAGE AND LANGUAGE CHANGES

There have been cases in which patients with brain injury appeared to wake up speaking a different language or with a different accent. Foreign accent syndrome is one example of such a medical condition. These cases are rare, and there have not been sufficient scientific studies carried out to understand them in any detail.

HELLO
SHWMAE BONJOUR
ASALAAM ALAIKUM
GUTEN TAG
PRIVET OLÁ
KONNICHIWA
HOLA CIAO

Speaking and understanding
Processing language is a complex task. Articulating or decoding even a simple greeting, such as “hello,” requires several different areas of the brain to work together.